

Laura Marshall

Designer Advocate · Design Systems

Portfolio lauramarshall.design

Contact lauraa.marshall@outlook.com

07531 759 386

Experience

Design Systems & Visual Design Lead

IBM · 2019–present

Design systems · Product design

Seven years at IBM as both a practitioner and advocate — building the Carbon for IBM Products Figma kit, teaching design-to-code workflows, and creating the guidance and community structures that helped hundreds of designers and engineers work together more effectively.

Career highlights include

- Leading a team of 10 designers to build the Carbon for IBM Products **Figma** kit from scratch — token architecture, **Figma variables**, 30+ components, **165% adoption growth** in five months — plus the documentation, workshops, and enablement content that drove adoption.
- Researching design-to-development collaboration across **100+ developers in 12 countries** — publishing guidance and workshops that brought design and engineering into shared ownership; presented at the **IBM Design Festival**.
- Leading a team to migrate **8 newly acquired products onto a shared design system in 9 months** — governance model, compliance framework, and leadership reporting.
- Contributing components, patterns, and written guidance to Carbon from product work — button guidance, full page errors, tag overflow, grid influencers — plus video walkthroughs on how to use Figma kits, driving all of it through the formal contribution process into IBM-wide standards.
- Using AI-assisted workflows to contribute HTML and CSS fixes into production code — the first designer in my organisation to do so — then sharing those workflows across the design community through internal talks.
- Mentoring **12+ designers** across my career — on design systems, contribution processes, and visual design craft.

Industry Lecturer

University of Reading · 2019–2025

Alongside my full-time role at IBM, I voluntarily led a compulsory second-year module for six years — teaching user-centred design, design thinking, and design systems to cohorts of 100+ students. Built and delivered all materials, workshops, individual feedback, and annual careers conversations. A student I taught was later hired at IBM — and has since taken over leading the module.

"A particular focus was on use of Figma and developing effective workflows into student design practice." — Rachel Warner, Graphic Communication Lecturer, UoR

Education

First Class – BA Graphic Communication

University of Reading · 2019

Published research

Braille in an evolving technological world

Visible Language Journal · 2020

Research into people's experiences of Braille as a reading method. Published in the oldest peer-reviewed design journal, with an acceptance rate below 20%.

Speaking & community

Nationwide · Client AI Workshop

IBM · 2026

Presented Figma Make and AI-assisted design workflows to Nationwide stakeholders — live demo: working prototype built from a paper sketch during the session.

Carbon Migration Workshop · Bangalore

IBM · 2025

Three-day workshop for 30+ designers and tech leads — **21/21** agreed it fully met its objectives.

Hursley Americas Summit

IBM · 2025

Presented early design concepts to external IBM clients — one fifth of all summit attendees.

IBM Design Festival · Design Shares

IBM · 2022–2024

Developer handoff talk to IBM's global design community; Design Shares on design system adoption.

Awards

Technical Collaboration Achievement Programme

IBM · 2023, 2024

Significant contributions to Carbon for IBM Products and the broader open source ecosystem.

Growth Award

IBM · 2022

Exceptional leadership delivering the Carbon for IBM Products Figma kit — essential to IBM's move to Figma.

Carbon Champion

IBM · 2022, 2024

Recognised twice for aligning Carbon across product teams and creating the Product Gallery.

Patents

Artificial Intelligence Prioritization of Abnormal Radiology Scans

US Patent Office · 2022

ML system that pre-reads scans and surfaces the most critical cases first — filed before AI tooling was a mainstream product conversation.